added over eighty packets of Tibetan rolls and convolutes, as well as eleven huge Tibetan Pōthīs, about 2 feet 5 inches long and 8 inches wide, with a height of nearly $1\frac{1}{2}$ feet, which appeared to be in fair order and to contain uniformly written portions of the Kanjur.

Bundles sewn up in canvas wrappers.

Almost all the bundles were sewn up tightly in coarse canvas covers, as seen in the case of the specimens which *Desert Cathay*, ii. Fig. 194, reproduces unopened. Whether these covers are old or were added after the discovery of the chapel I have not been able definitely to ascertain. Wang Tao-shih asserted the former. The ends of the covers were generally left open. Thus, as Wang handed out bundle after bundle through the chapel door, I was with Chiang's help just able to look hastily whether, embedded between the usual Chinese rolls, there were to be found any Pōthī leaves or other non-Chinese texts, folded-up small pictures, or other relics of obvious interest. Such we endeavoured to pick out as well as time would permit, and put them aside rapidly. But there was no time then even to glance at individual rolls and to see by unfolding them whether their reverses bore anywhere Indian or Central-Asian scripts or what else might be hidden within.

Art relics in 'mixed' bundles on floor.

In view of the Tao-shih's visibly growing reluctance, it did not appear safe at this stage to attempt any proper search which would necessarily have delayed the clearing. But perfunctory as the operation had to be, its timely completion brought a gratifying reward in the discovery at the very bottom of a number of large 'mixed' bundles (Ch. xlvi–lvii). They had been put by Wang Tao-shih to what he thought appropriate use in turning the floor at the foot of the north wall and on either side of the clay-built platform into a foundation level with the latter on which to build up his wall of manuscript bundles. They proved to contain a considerable number of exquisite silk paintings, several of exceptionally large size, and some beautiful textile pieces. Apart from the very instructive patchwork hangings (Ch. lv. 0028, Plates CVII, CVIII), it must suffice here to mention the magnificent embroidery picture, Plate CIV,[3] showing a Buddha between Bodhisattvas in life size. Owing to the heavy crushing which these bundles had been exposed to through their position low down on the ground, the recovery of the silk paintings contained in them required special care, and kept me busy during the greater part of the following day.

Negotiations with Wang Tao-shih.

At the same time lengthy negotiations ensued with the Tao-shih. Whether it was from the fear of increased risks of exposure or merely because he regretted having put, as it seemed, within our reach those precious Chinese Sūtra texts to which alone he seemed to attach particular value, he thought fit to press at this stage for an early end of our proceedings. While asking for a substantial subscription to his temple, he yet protested that any cession of sacred texts or 'Chings'—and among these he classed all Chinese manuscript rolls, whatever their contents might be—was impossible. Though this attitude was far from encouraging, I was glad that the Tao-shih came to business, as it were; for the preceding work had fully convinced me that it was my duty towards research to try my utmost to rescue the whole of this precious collection from the risk of slow dispersion and loss with which it was threatened in such keeping. But I also realized fully the serious difficulties and objections with which this course was beset. I was not qualified to form any definite estimate of the philological value of those masses of Chinese Buddhist texts which made up the bulk of the hidden library. Their contents were, no doubt, to be found in the complete editions of the Chinese *Tripiṭaka*, printed in Korea and Japan. Still less could I profitably attempt to select those texts which were likely to possess antiquarian or literary interest. The removal of whole cart-loads of manuscripts would inevitably lead to the whole transaction becoming public, and this was likely to compromise my chances of further work elsewhere. As regards Tun-huang itself, there was a special reason to avoid anything that might arouse religious resentment with its possibly serious consequences; for I knew through my Mandarin friends of the popular unrest, caused

Impossibility of complete removal.

[3] Cf. regarding this embroidery picture, below, pp. 895 sq.

locally by certain fiscal measures, which within a month after my departure actually found vent in a serious outbreak, and which it would have been obviously unwise to precipitate by any action on my part.

Attempt to secure whole hoard.

I decided, nevertheless, rather to face these risks than forgo the endeavour to rescue the whole hoard. Though Chiang Ssŭ-yeh did not conceal from me misgivings justified by his knowledge of local conditions, he loyally did his best to persuade the Tao-shih that removal of the collection to a 'temple of learning' in India, or in the land of those who held sway of the ancient home of Buddhism, would be an act which might well be approved as pious. The big sum I had authorized Chiang to offer for the collection, if ceded in bulk (40 'horseshoes' of silver, about Rs. 5,000, which I should have been prepared to double if need be), was used by him as a powerful argument. It would enable Wang to retire to his native province and a life of peace, if Tun-huang should become too hot for him. Or else he might spend it all on new structures for religious use near the cave-temple, which by his restoration he could claim to have annexed as his own with all its contents known or unknown, and thus secure much-increased merit and glory.

Difficulties encountered with priest.

Arguments and pleadings proved vain. Having before resignedly closed his eyes to my gathering whatever I thought of special artistic or antiquarian interest, the Tao-shih now manifestly became frightened by the prospect of losing his precious 'Chings' as a whole. A display of sulky petulance on his part made, for the first time, our relations become somewhat strained, and only by very careful handling did we obviate what threatened to become a breach. The Tao-shih persisted in urging with all signs of sincere anxiety that any deficiency in those piles of sacred texts was bound to be noticed by his patrons, whose publicly recorded subscriptions had helped him to clear and restore the temple; this would lead to the loss of the position which he had built up for himself in the district by the pious labours of eight years and to the destruction of his life's task. Former scruples reasserting themselves, he reproached himself for having given up sacred objects which his patrons had as much right to control as he had, and doggedly asserted the need of consulting them before taking any further step.

Agreement arrived at with Wang Tao-shih.

These discussions, carried on intermittently, helped to gain time for the clearing of the newly disclosed mixed bundles, and by the evening of the second day it was completed. But when I returned early next morning in order to start the close search of the regular Chinese bundles for any remnants of Central-Asian texts or other relics of special interest that might be hidden among their rolls, I found to my dismay that the priest, seized by a fit of perturbation and qualms, had found strength to shift back overnight almost the whole of them to their gloomy hiding-place. The exertion which this *coup* had cost him only added to the sullenness of his temper. But the quantity of valuable paintings, non-Chinese manuscripts, and other relics already removed gave us a material advantage. This, and the Tao-shih's unmistakable wish to secure a substantial sum of money for new building operations that he contemplated, led at last to what I could well consider a substantial success in our protracted diplomatic struggle. The agreement arrived at assured me fifty compact bundles of Chinese, and five of Tibetan, text rolls, besides all my selections from the 'mixed' bundles which had passed through my hands. The payment made for all these acquisitions amounted to four 'horseshoes' of silver, or about Rs. 500. When I now survey the wealth of archaeological materials alone that I carried away for this sum, the bargain may well seem great beyond credence.

Secret removal of 'selections'.

The experience gained of the Tao-shih's pusillanimous frame of mind made me doubly anxious to lose no time in removing the heavy loads of Chinese and Tibetan rolls. So far it had been my devoted Chinese secretary who night by night struggled to my tent with the loads of my daily 'selections'. But the new task being wholly beyond his strength, I sought help on this occasion

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from Ibrāhīm Bēg and Tila Bai, another trusted old follower. Two midnight trips which they made to the temple with Chiang, under the screening shadow of the steep river-bank, allowed the huge sackfuls to be safely removed to my store-room without any one, even of my own men, having received an inkling. Prolonged absence from his clients in the oasis had caused the nervousness of Wang Tao-shih to increase. So as soon as our transaction was completed he hastened to resume his seasonal begging tour in the district.

Further acquisitions and packing.

In order to assuage his spiritual scruples as well as I could, and to give visible proof of grateful attachment to my 'patron saint's' memory, I had previously arranged through the priest to have one of the abandoned smaller shrines in the southern group of grottoes redecorated with a new clay image of Hsüan-tsang. The Tun-huang sculptor's work in due time produced an artistic eyesore, but widely advertised by the Tao-shih it helped to dispel suspicions about my long visit. So when a week later he returned I found him reassured that the secret had not been discovered, and that his spiritual influence, such as it was, had suffered no diminution. Thus it became possible to make him stretch a point further and allow me to acquire some twenty more bundles of Chinese manuscripts, with supplementary selections from the 'mixed' bundles, against an appropriate donation for his temple. When later on I proceeded to the packing, the manuscript acquisitions filled seven cases, such as horses could carry, while five more were required to hold the paintings, decorated textiles, and other miscellaneous relics. The safe packing of the painted silks proved to be a very delicate task needing great care, and I was glad to utilize for it the days when sand-storms made photographic work in the caves impossible. The risk of causing suspicion in Tun-huang by a sudden large order of cases was avoided by the precaution I had taken to bring some 'empties' to the site and by securing the rest by discreet instalments.

Departure from 'Thousand Buddhas'.

The forethought and care bestowed on such necessary safeguards did not remain unrequited. I had the satisfaction of seeing that the shy Tao-shih, honest in his own way, now breathed freely again. It seemed almost as if in a dim way he recognized that it was a pious act on his part to let me rescue for Western scholarship as much as circumstances would permit of those ancient Buddhist relics which local ignorance would allow to lie here neglected or to be lost in the end. When I finally took my departure from the 'Halls of the Thousand Buddhas', his quaint, sharp-cut face had resumed its customary expression of shy but self-contented serenity. We parted in fullest amity. But the most gratifying proof I received of the peaceful state of his mind was when, on my return to An-hsi four months later, he agreed to give up, for that 'temple of learning' in the distant West of which I had told him so often, another big share of the Chinese and Tibetan manuscripts in the shape of over two hundred and thirty compact bundles. How this was successfully achieved through Chiang Ssŭ-yeh's persuasive diplomacy and in perfect secrecy has been told in my Personal Narrative.[4] But it was only when all the twenty-four cases heavy with manuscripts rescued from the priest's precarious keeping, and the five more filled with paintings and other art remains from the same hoard, had been safely deposited in the British Museum that I could feel true relief.

Section IV.—Subsequent Investigations of the Deposit

Detailed record of observations.

In giving above so full an account of my efforts and labours at the old library hidden away in Wang Tao-shih's temple I was guided mainly by two considerations. On the one hand, it was regard for the exceptional importance which may be claimed for this great deposit of early manuscripts and art remains, probably the largest ever brought to light in modern times within the

[4] See *Desert Cathay*, ii. p. 339.

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ditions in which I found the Uigur books in question are in full accord. The two 'mixed' bundles in which, as my notes taken at the time show, they turned up came from the top of the solid pile of regular 'library' packets, and were but loosely wrapped up in large sheets of canvas once painted. The bundle Ch. xix, from which the Uigur book with the colophon apparently dated came, was handed out to me, as I distinctly remember, practically open, and the Uigur books were lying exposed on the top. In addition to them it contained big packets of Tibetan Pōthī leaves, of different sizes and all mixed in confusion, besides small parcels, tightly fastened, of votive rags in a variety of fabrics.

Probable *terminus ad quem* of original deposit.

Summing up the facts just stated, there appears to be a strong presumption that the dated Uigur book and those of similar character represent an addition made to the old deposit between 1900 and 1907, just like the modern Taoist print above referred to. It is, of course, impossible definitely to prove that they are the *only* additions received by the hoard during those years in which, as we know, it was kept accessible for occasional visitors, repeatedly disarranged, and drawn upon for presents to donors and persons of consequence.[10] But considering that the close search made by M. Pelliot and that which, in the case of my own collection, was subsequently carried out at the British Museum have failed to bring to light among those many thousands of texts and documents any others of probably later origin, it must appear very unlikely that any other additions actually occurred within those few years following the discovery of 1900. The same argument holds good also, as far as archaeological reasoning can go, against any theory which would assume that the deposit was walled up at some date later than the early part of the eleventh century, and, perhaps, was reopened and closed again between that period and the year 1900. But it must be admitted that the antiquarian evidence available for the *terminus ad quem* is not such as would be accepted as conclusive in a court of law. Nor would it be reasonable to expect this, considering the conditions under which the discovery of 1900 actually took place and those since prevailing at the site.[11]

Fate of manuscripts left behind with the Tao-shih.

It only remains for me to relate briefly the fortunes of the still very considerable stock of the old library which remained in Wang Tao-shih's keeping after M. Pelliot's visit. The news of the important Chinese manuscripts discovered and brought away by him had quickly spread among men of learning in China, through the report published at Hanoi and probably otherwise also. During Professor Pelliot's stay at Peking in the early part of 1909, Chinese scholars of the capital, including a learned viceroy, had eagerly studied and photographed any precious manuscripts that he had kept with him.[12] So it did not take long before an order was issued by the central Government directing the prompt transmission of the whole library to the capital, a substantial sum in compensation being decreed for those in charge of the temple.

Removal of manuscripts to Peking; losses *en route*.

The information I received on my return to Tun-huang in March, 1914, left little doubt as to the characteristic manner in which this well-intentioned order from headquarters had been carried out, apparently towards the close of 1909 or soon after. According to the statement of Wang Tao-shih, who hastened to welcome me back as an old and cherished patron, the large sum of money assigned in compensation to his temple had completely vanished *en route*, being duly absorbed, no doubt, in its transit through the different Ya-mêns. The whole collection of manuscripts

[10] Cf. Pelliot, *B.É.F.E.O.*, 1908, p. 506.

[11] The explanations here given render it unnecessary specially to discuss the remarks made by the late Mr. H. Amedroz in his note, *J.R.A.S.*, 1913, pp. 694 sqq., with reference to Dr. Ross's above-quoted statement. Based as they necessarily are on preliminary information obtained second-hand, they can touch only what may be called the quasi-legal aspect of the question. I may, however, rectify a statement (p. 695, clause 2) which is due to some misapprehension. There is nothing in my narrative—*Desert Cathay* is meant—justifying the belief that the manuscript dated A.D. 1350 'came out of one of the "compact bundles" piled in the walled-up library'.

[12] Cf. *Bulletin du Comité de l'Asie fr.*, 1910, pp. 23 sq.

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was taken away in carts, packed in a very perfunctory fashion, and after some delay at the Tun-huang Ya-mên started on its long way to Peking. A good deal of pilfering was known to have occurred already while the carts were kept waiting at Tun-huang, as proved by the bundles of fine Buddhist text rolls of T'ang times which were brought to me for sale there, and acquired at modest rates. The guarding of the convoy must have been equally careless further on, as similar opportunities for rescuing relics of the great *cache* were also offered to me at Su-chou and Kan-chou. Other packets of Ch'ien-fo-tung rolls must have been carried away into Hsin-chiang, where I was shown a number of such old manuscripts at different Ya-mêns and could myself secure some more from Chinese petty employés, etc. I must leave it to others to ascertain how much of the original collection actually arrived in Peking, and what care it has found there.

Manuscript acquisitions renewed in 1914.

In view of the official treatment which Wang Tao-shih's cherished store of 'Chings' had thus suffered, I did not feel surprise at his now expressing bitter regret that he had not possessed the courage and wisdom to accept the big offer I had made in 1907 through Chiang Ssŭ-yeh for the whole collection. His devout *clientèle* among the Tun-huang population, seeing how well he had laid out the sums received, first from myself and then from Pei Ta-jên, i.e. M. Pelliot, in building new gaudy chapels and a large, comfortable hospice, seemed to agree in sharing his feelings. They, no doubt, fully approved too of the shrewd precaution which the honest Taoist monk had taken against the official spoliation of the temple becoming too complete. Before the removal above referred to, supposed to be wholesale, took place, he had managed to store away in a safe place a nest-egg, as it were, of such Chinese manuscripts as he conceived to be of special value. It must have been considerable in extent; for even after what Mr. Tachibana in 1911 had been able to acquire from this reserve store, there remained enough to allow me to carry away, as a fruit of my renewed pilgrimage to the site, five cases filled with Chinese manuscript rolls, most of them in a particularly good state of preservation. That the donation made in return to the shrine had to be raised in proportion to the increased fame of the original hoard is obvious—and equally also the doubt whether the reserve has even now become completely exhausted. And here 'the Prieste's Tale' from the Caves of the Thousand Buddhas may fitly end for the present.

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I had been unable to examine closely or to remove during my visit to the Thousand Buddhas. But it certainly looks as if during the centuries before the walling-up of the monastic library the connexion of Tun-huang with the Buddhist communities south of the Taklamakān had been closer than with those in the northern oases from Turfān to Kuchā.

Collection of Chinese manuscripts.

The account given above in Chapter XXII will have shown that, notwithstanding my want of Sinologist knowledge, I realized from the first the importance of the masses of Chinese manuscripts which made up the main contents of the great hoard. Evidence secured through Chiang Ssŭ-yeh's help soon showed me the antiquarian interest of the miscellaneous local records and the often earlier origin of the broken manuscript remains which were to be found particularly in the mixed bundles. The special attention I paid to the acquisition of the latter has since been further justified by the fact that among them the proportion of lay texts with historical or philological value has proved much greater than among the compact bundles containing for the most part well-preserved rolls of Buddhist canonical literature. The number of individual rolls in the 270 odd regular bundles which I secured in the end in addition to previous 'selections' proved so great that, when at last in July, 1908, there was leisure to set Chiang Ssŭ-yeh to work at them, the weeks available before my final departure from Khotan sufficed only for a first rapid listing of less than a third of them. Even thus the rough inventory proved useful by showing that among the manuscripts then unrolled there were to be found dated colophons reaching back to the fifth century A.D. if not earlier.

Chinese manuscripts examined by Prof. Pelliot.

After the collection had been safely brought to the British Museum, nothing could be done for the examination of the Chinese manuscripts from Ch'ien-fo-tung filling twenty-four cases until in the early summer of 1910 Professor Pelliot to my great satisfaction came to London and devoted several weeks of unremitting labour to a rapid examination of those manuscripts. His exceptional qualifications as a Sinologist, and the unique experience gained through his preceding labours at the great *cache* itself, enabled him to arrive soon at a safe estimate of the general character and value of our materials in spite of their great mass. At my request Professor Pelliot was kind enough to sum up the main result of his observations in a brief but very instructive memorandum (reproduced below), and at the same time to express his readiness to undertake under certain conditions the preparation of a systematic inventory of our Chinese manuscripts from Tun-huang. I felt most grateful for this arrangement, which promised within a reasonable time to render this important part of our collection fully accessible to research through the work of the scholar best qualified for the task. The proposal soon received also the sanction of the India Office and the British Museum Trustees, into whose possession all Chinese manuscripts brought back from my expedition were ultimately to pass.

Arrangements for cataloguing Chinese MSS.

In the autumn of 1910 a first instalment of manuscripts was duly transmitted to Professor Pelliot at Paris for the purpose of being catalogued. But, owing to personal circumstances and the pressure of other scientific tasks, their inventory had not been completed by the summer of 1914, when the outbreak of the war called Professor Pelliot to military duty in the French Army. As on account of other obligations he was unable to resume these labours, the preparation of a detailed catalogue was undertaken by Dr. L. Giles at the British Museum.[17a] Meanwhile this portion of the collection having attracted due attention in Japan, several very competent scholars, such as Professor Kano and Mr. Taki in 1912–13 and Mr. Yabuki in 1916, had devoted

and Meillet's just-quoted paper makes it impossible for me to determine which of them came from Ch'ien-fo-tung and which from Duldul-ākhur and other Kuchā sites.

[17a At the time of going to press over 2,000 separate manuscripts have already been catalogued.]